performance.” In 1969, an interagency group acknowledged that the US still had an “interest in India’s ability to defend its borders against Asia’s one big Communist power,” but there was a sense that India seemed to be militarily capable enough to “defend itself simultaneously” against China and Pakistan. American officials believed that India was most vulnerable to internal “fragility,” which kept the focus on bolstering India’s economic development and political stability rather than its defense resources.[13]

Neither the focus on development nor Nixon’s approach to assistance was altogether unwelcome in Delhi. By the time Nixon took office, the Indian economy had improved considerably. India, however, still needed foreign assistance. And Nixon assured visiting Indian foreign minister Dinesh Singh in July that development assistance would continue.[14] Gandhi’s senior aide Parmeshwar Narayan (P. N.) Haksar approvingly noted that the new administration was also not questioning India’s defense expenditures.[15] In addition, unlike Johnson, Nixon only wanted to review major economic assistance packages annually. On Kissinger’s recommendation, the president did not make a small piecemeal commitment—partly to make evident that his approach was going to be a “marked contrast” to that of Johnson’s short-tether policy. In July 1969, Nixon approved a $300 million PL-480 package and a $35 million loan for India. This was in addition to the $55 million worth of food aid he had initially sanctioned as part of a continuing program for India. The next year, he would approve $193 million in economic assistance for India.[16]

Nixon’s changing assessment of China reinforced the emphasis on economic relations with India. While Johnson administration officials had doubted the feasibility of India playing a role vis-à-vis China, the Nixon White House also questioned the desirability of seeking such a role.

Anticipating Indian concern about US normalizing relations with China, officials sought to prepare the ground.[17] In May 1969, Secretary of State William Rogers—who was not aware of all the details of Nixon’s China plans—admitted to the Indian prime minister that the US was “seeking” to talk to China. Gandhi recalled her own overtures to China, noting, however, that “there had been no reaction.” Kissinger, in turn, told Indian ambassador Ali Yavar Jung that “the US may have an easier chance than the USSR to normalize relations with China.” Nixon subsequently indicated to the Indian foreign minister that he did not buy the conventional wisdom “that the way